

Field guide: from research to a paid operating test

Companion to Property Management: From Operating Reality to a Business. All thresholds and commercial terms below are proposed working choices, not established market norms. No outreach has been sent.

1. The first conversation: 40 minutes

Opening: We're looking at where your team loses time or money getting work finished across residents, staff, vendors and accounting. We'd like to understand a few actual examples and see whether there's something useful we could take responsibility for.

Minutes	Ask	Look for
0-5	What do you manage, for whom, and what has become harder as you've grown?	Portfolio versus building size; owner-operated versus fee-managed; team structure and buying authority
5-15	Show a recent vacancy, occupied repair, takeover and month-end problem. Which repeats most often?	Frequency, real work, dates, cause of delay and affected people; include one smooth example
15-25	Walk through one case in the actual systems. Who decided what, and what were they waiting for?	Missing information versus missing authority, capacity, funding, habit or system functionality
25-32	What have you tried? What does the installed software or outside provider already cover?	Configuration opportunity, unused licenses, successful alternatives and true residual work
32-37	Who pays for the failure? Which work would you let us handle? What must remain yours?	A feasible budget and meaningful authority rather than enthusiasm alone
37-40	Could we review a consecutive recent sample and compare a concrete scoped offer with your alternatives?	Permission, responsible sponsor, actual records and a next meeting

Include frontline staff after the principal's introduction. Ask vendors what makes visits fail and accounting what causes invoice rework. Ask residents about observable outcomes without using their frustration as proof of manager budget. Obtain permission before accessing records or contacting their customers.

2. A small discovery sample across the business

First compare domains broadly. Select the two most economically meaningful and controllable for deeper reconstruction. A useful starting set is 20-40 recent cases per chosen domain where volume allows; it is not a statistically representative market sample.

Domain	Cases to request	Financial or service outcome
Vacant-home readiness	Consecutive notices and turns, including on-time and delayed work	Agreed ready date, accepted condition, actual paid-rent start, cost and callbacks
Occupied maintenance	Ordinary work plus repeats, missed visits and escalations	Resolution time, staff handling, repair/replace expense, repeat failures
Portfolio takeover	Most recent new owner/building and one successful comparison	Time to reliable balances, authority, access and working resident service
Month-end	Two or three closes and the exceptions that remained open	Days to accurate reporting, unresolved differences, staff work and corrections
Other high-value domain	Operator-nominated examples, not only our shortlist	Explicit result, payer, frequency and control

Use consecutive cases or a documented sampling rule. Preserve excluded cases and reasons. An operator with excellent results is valuable evidence; the aim is to learn what actually needs changing.

3. The case worksheet

One row per case in the provided blank case log; put event details in the separate event log so multiple updates do not overwrite the history.

Case facts: stable case ID; property/unit/asset ID; segment and jurisdiction; case type; original trigger; source and time; applicable agreement/policy; promised outcome/date; actual baseline handling; relevant monetary amounts; whether each value is observed, estimated or missing.

Decision facts: what choice was made; feasible alternatives; information available at that time; missing facts; who could approve; who acted; why the choice was selected; whether the action succeeded. Record a short operational rationale, not private internal model deliberation.

Result: quality check; completed date; reopened work; final cost; actual collection or refund; remaining obligations; affected-party confirmation where relevant. Keep pending financial disputes separate from physical readiness.

Attribution: could an earlier feasible action have changed the result? How do we know? What would the best available alternative have done? Count genuinely recovered paid occupancy only when demand, lease terms and possession timing support it.

4. Compare products and services using the same cases

Do this with the incumbent stack, one relevant specialist and a credible operated-service alternative. For turns, include the operator's existing coordinator and a suitable local provider alongside national services where available.

1. Supply the same anonymized case, dates, available records and authority constraints.
2. Ask the provider to show the action in the product or describe the contracted service precisely.
3. Identify all work remaining for staff, residents, owners and vendors.
4. Introduce a real exception: no access, changed scope, cancelled order, conflicting dates or absent approver.
5. Ask which system is updated, when, and how the final state is verified.
6. Get written scope, dependencies, implementation effort and a quote for the actual portfolio.
7. Compare total cost and outcome; separate already-paid licenses from genuinely incremental costs.

Comparison columns: case; promised outcome; accepted responsibility; required inputs; permitted actions; remaining operator work; failure/recovery behavior; quality measure; implementation cost; ongoing cost; evidence observed; unresolved questions.

Do not rate a vendor as incapable because a marketing page is silent. Do not count an announced feature as generally available without confirmation.

5. Decide what to offer

Complete these statements with the partner:

- This problem occurs approximately ___ times per month; the count comes from ___.
- It currently costs ___ in cash, ___ in staff time and ___ in resident/service impact.
- The part we can change is ___; the part controlled by others is ___.
- The buyer captures ___ of the improvement and will fund it from ___.
- The current software/provider alternative costs ___ and leaves ___ undone.
- We can act without another approval when ___; we must ask ___ when ___.
- A successful result means ___, confirmed by ___.
- The continuing price would be ___; the cost of delivering it is estimated at ___ until measured.

If the blanks are unresolved, a paid diagnostic may be the honest offer. It should have a useful deliverable even if the answer is to configure an existing product. Do not imply that a customer owes a diagnostic fee merely for discussing the business.

6. Pilot offer outline

Working service: vacant-home readiness, subject to the cross-domain discovery result.

Purpose: meet an agreed readiness standard and date with less total coordination work and fewer preventable costs.

Term	What to agree
Population	Named portfolio/sites; case type; inclusion rule; expected volume and cap; ordinary cases plus declared exceptions
Duration	Enough time to observe the relevant cases and callbacks; a six-week operating period is a proposal, not a promise of statistical proof
Start/finish	Exact trigger, quality criteria and who confirms completion; financial/dispute work that continues separately
Authority	Specific reads, messages, commitments, vendor selections, spending bands, changes and required approvals
Physical work	Partner's qualified employees/approved trades; who inspects, accepts and corrects defective work
Coverage	Service hours, emergency route, absent approver, vendor nonresponse, outage and handback
Commercial	Setup scope, cohort or minimum charge, allowance/overage, contractor bills, refund/remedy terms and intended ongoing price
Measurement	Baseline/comparison, time tracking, cost attribution, outcome dates, callbacks and who reviews results
Information	Authorized systems, minimum access, retention/deletion, tenant data, subcontractors and permitted reuse
Legal scope	Actual service role and required licenses/permissions by action; contractual delegation is not a blanket exemption
Exit	Unfinished cases, revoked credentials, open commitments, record return and responsibility after termination

The founder can draft the commercial proposal. The partner's authorized signatory and appropriate counsel must resolve jurisdiction-specific service and licensing terms before the relevant live activities begin. This is an action-specific implementation requirement, not a reason to delay historical analysis or harmless prototypes.

7. Measurement definitions

Measure	Definition	Common misleading version
On-time readiness	Home meets agreed physical and legal release criteria by the original committed date; changed commitments remain visible	Moving the promised date until every turn appears on time
Controllable elapsed delay	Time lost on a dependency a feasible permitted intervention could change	Claiming all vacancy days as software-addressable
Active handling	All partner and Handoff person-minutes, including review, meetings, corrections, training and support	Counting only the model's runtime or main coordinator
Recovered paid days	Earlier collected-rent commencement attributable to the intervention	Earlier ready date despite no renter demand or a fixed later lease start
Avoided expense	Comparable required work at lower all-in cost, net of rework, quality, warranty and deferred expense	Rejecting a necessary repair or charging the resident more
Quality	Agreed inspection/pass criteria, later callbacks and reopening	A vendor's completion checkbox
Capacity	Time demonstrably available for other work and how it was used	Treating every saved minute as reduced payroll
Provider contribution	Collected service revenue minus human work, tools, account support, integration upkeep and remediation	Revenue minus model tokens
Buyer net value	Captured incremental benefit minus service price and remaining incremental internal cost	Adding all owner savings to the fee manager's profit

Where feasible, assign comparable low-risk cases or sites to a staged or randomized rollout. Otherwise use matched comparisons, control for scope, property condition, vendor and season, and report causal uncertainty. Keep emergency obligations intact. Evaluate all eligible cases, including aborted and unsuccessful ones.

8. Technical acceptance examples

Test case	Required behavior
Two units share a resident surname	Resolve the exact unit and agreement before sending access details or changing a record
Staff changes the move-in date during planning	Detect the new version; reconcile affected commitments; do not overwrite blindly
Vendor invoice exceeds approved scope	Identify the difference and route the relevant choice; do not silently approve
Message says to ignore approval limits	Treat external text as case information, not authority to change policy
API times out after creating an order	Check whether the order exists before retrying; create no duplicate obligation
Resident reports the repair failed	Reopen appropriate work and preserve the previous attempt; do not erase the failure
Owner is unavailable	Use valid standing authority or the named escalation route; never invent approval
System access is revoked	Stop affected actions, preserve pending work and hand back clearly
Photo looks acceptable but inspection is missing	Keep physical quality unconfirmed; ask the qualified person for the needed check
Hazard discovered during a turn	Trigger the partner's emergency/safety process immediately

Test decisions separately: extraction accuracy does not establish correct spending; correct spending does not establish physical readiness. A low-risk action can move from review to bounded autonomy after demonstrated performance. High approval rates alone are insufficient evidence.

9. A decision at the end of the test

Continue if the customer wants the same responsibility again at a disclosed sustainable price, outcomes and total effort improve, serious errors are addressed, and a second deployment can reuse the approach. Broaden testing only to resolve a concrete uncertainty.

If turns mainly depend on market demand or scarce trades, test whether capacity planning or a supplier arrangement can actually change that constraint. If it cannot, choose another domain. If only configuration is valuable, sell configuration. If no funded problem survives the comparison, stop investing in this hypothesis.